

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Getty Images

Donald Trump insisted that **America's** [ceasefire](#) with **Iran** remained in place, despite both sides attacking one another on Thursday. Iran accused America of targeting an Iranian oil tanker and hitting civilian targets in Tehran. America said it had responded to Iranian attacks on its warships and had only struck military targets in self-defence. The fighting comes as Iran is considering an American proposal to end the war.

Britain's ruling **Labour Party** looked to have suffered a drubbing in **local elections**. In early results it lost control of several local councils. Reform UK, a populist-right party, is on course to gain hundreds of seats. If the final count is as bad as expected for Labour, [Sir Keir Starmer](#), the country's beleaguered prime minister, will face pressure to resign.

America's Court of International Trade struck down Mr Trump's 10% global **tariffs**. Most of the tariffs will remain in place while the administration appeals. The president imposed the new levies in February after the Supreme Court blocked the majority of his "Liberation Day" [tariffs](#). Meanwhile Mr Trump gave the European Union until July 4th to ratify a trade deal, or face "much higher" tariffs.

The Economist revealed [evidence](#) of a secret **Russian plan** to supply innovative weapons to **Iran** to be used against American troops. The three-part proposal, seen exclusively by our journalists, was prepared by the GRU, the intelligence arm of Russia's armed forces. It posited sending two types of drones to Iran—including **fibre-optic** models, which have transformed the [battlefield](#) in Ukraine—and providing training.

Mr Trump and **Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva**, Brazil's president, discussed trade, tariffs and crime during a meeting at the White House. Despite the leaders' [frosty relationship](#), both reported that the conversation went well. Last year Mr Trump briefly imposed 50% tariffs on Brazil over the [prosecution](#) of former president Jair Bolsonaro, an ally, for plotting a coup d'état.

Health authorities around the world scrambled to track down people connected to a cruise ship where an outbreak of **hantavirus** killed three people. The World Health Organisation has confirmed five of eight suspected cases of the [rodent-borne virus](#). A WHO epidemiologist said that, as human-to-human infection is rare, this was “not the start of a pandemic”.

Two men were found guilty of **spying** for Hong Kong in **Britain**. A court ruled that Bill Yuen, an office manager at Hong Kong's trade office in London, and Peter Wai, a British immigration officer, agreed to gather information on dissidents to help the Chinese territory's foreign-intelligence service. China said the charges were fabricated.

Figure of the day: 23%, how much the population of under-18s in Los Angeles fell by between 2010 and 2024. In Chicago the figure was 22%. [Read how](#) cities across America are losing children fast.



Photograph: Reuters

Misery in America

America's economy is sending mixed signals. Despite the Iran war, the s&p 500 is soaring. Yet [the energy shock](#) and a softening labour market remain threats. On Friday the Bureau of Labour Statistics reports jobs data for April and the University of Michigan releases a preliminary reading of its consumer-sentiment index for May.

Last month the index fell to a record low, as pump prices rose by around 50% against pre-war levels. Analysts expect more gloom this month. But the labour market is holding up: employers are expected to add 55,000 jobs in April, down from 178,000 in March. America last added jobs for two consecutive months in May 2025.

How much these signals matter is less clear. [Consumer pessimism](#) is yet to seriously dent spending. Payroll growth has slowed owing to an ageing population and immigration restrictions. Economists now pay closer attention to unemployment—and whether consumer gloom will ever pass through to the real economy.



Photograph: Getty Images

A coming food shock

In April the United Nations' Food and Agriculture Organisation warned of a “perfect storm” brewing for a food catastrophe. On Friday the FAO's food-price index will hint at how close the clouds are. March's reading showed a mild monthly increase. But that is because pre-existing stocks of commodities like cereals offset supply-chain snarls. April's increase will probably be more dramatic—and it still won't completely reflect reality. Disruptions to [fertiliser](#)—which requires crucial components from the Gulf—have not yet been fully felt.

Worse is yet to come. An El Niño, the warm phase of the world's oscillating climate pattern, is expected to begin this summer. Aggravated by climate change, it typically harms agriculture by intensifying droughts in some areas and drowning crops in others. But some cycles are worse than others. The “super” El Niño of 2015-16 caused crop production in Southern Africa to plummet by two-thirds; the one in 2023-24 left 30m people needing food assistance. Models suggest the [next El Niño](#) might be as severe, if not worse.



Photograph: Getty Images

The road ahead for Toyota

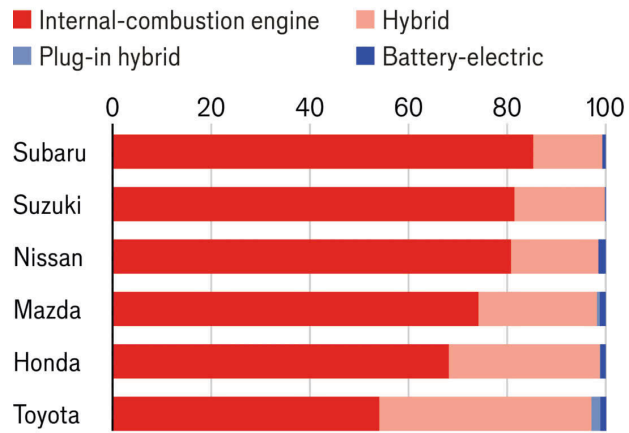
Japan's once-mighty carmakers are struggling with the industry's shift to electric vehicles, where China leads the way. Honda and Nissan are undergoing brutal restructurings. But Toyota has avoided that fate and remains the world's biggest carmaker by sales and net profit, in part thanks to its dominance in hybrids. On Friday it reported revenues of ¥50.68trn (\$323bn) in the year to March 31st, up around 1.9% from the previous financial year.

Still, the carmaker cannot afford to idle. Its operating profit declined by 19.2% to ¥3.85trn (\$25bn), in part because of the impact of American tariffs. And Chinese firms continue to churn out competitive models. Toyota's response has been to build in China, for China. Since 2023 it has launched four China-exclusive EVs, developed with local partners. Over a dozen more are in the works, according to Bernstein, a broker.

Toyota's EV sales remain low. But they doubled year on year in the first three months of 2026. And rising petrol prices have made alternatives more desirable—which could accelerate demand.

In the wrong lane

Selected Japanese carmakers,
vehicle sales, Q4 2025, % of total



Source: Bernstein



Photograph: Getty Images

America's new methane loophole

Friday was supposed to be the first full day in which American producers of oil and natural gas could no longer routinely burn off unwanted byproducts. But last week Donald Trump's [Environmental Protection Agency](#) issued new "guidance" on circumstances where such "routine flaring" could continue, including at new oil wells. The EPA said this was a "direct response to concerns from several oil and natural-gas owners and operators".

The practice releases pollutants like methane, a powerful greenhouse gas which warms the atmosphere 86 times more than carbon dioxide does over 20 years. A recent report by the International Energy Agency, a forecaster, on the global drive to reduce methane emissions shows no decline from the energy sector, despite the fact reductions would benefit producers as well as the planet. The IEA estimates that they could recoup 100bn cubic metres of natural gas each year—roughly equivalent to Australia's annual exports—by eliminating non-essential flaring and capturing the gas instead.



Photograph: BBC NHU/Alex Board

David Attenborough turns 100

How can you measure the impact of Sir David Attenborough, who turns 100 today? One way is to look at some of the other numbers that describe the career of the British naturalist and presenter. Such as the number of his honorary degrees (32); the number of locations his crew visited for his “Life on Earth” series (more than 100); and the number of people thought to have watched that series (500m).

But perhaps the most appropriate way to measure Sir David—who alerted much of the world to just how endangered many of its species are—would be to look at the number of species named after him. There are more than 50, at least one for every other year of his life. These include a lizard (*Platysaurus attenboroughi*), a pitcher plant (*Nepenthes attenboroughii*) and, less flatteringly, a dung beetle (*Sylvicanthon attenboroughi*). Thanks to his efforts, they have a better chance of surviving for at least another 100 years.



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: Which easy-listening singer had a long-running TV show in the 1960s and later established his own theatre in Branson, Missouri?

Thursday: Michael Stipe is the lead singer of which band from Athens, Georgia?

There is some risk involved in action, there always is. But there is far more risk in failure to act.

Harry S Truman